# Three First Moves for a Conversation You've Never Had

Permission, everyday life and a way to come back to it.

Your wife is well, and the subject of future care has never come up between you. Nothing has happened, there's nothing to decide and no date to meet. You'd simply like to know where a conversation like this starts.

It starts small. Three moves, in this order, with as much time between them as you like.

## 1 Ask her permission

Before anything else, ask whether she'd be willing to talk sometime about what she'd want to keep if things ever changed. Pick an ordinary moment. The Conversation Project's starter guide suggests the kitchen table, the car or a walk. If she says “not today,” that's her answer for today, and she can say when. [1] [3]

**WHY IT GOES HERE** A conversation she has agreed to belongs to both of you. One that arrives unannounced can sound like a plan already made.

## 2 Begin with everyday life, not with a move

Once she's said yes, ask about ordinary days: what a good one looks like, which routines she'd hate to lose, who she likes having around. Leave moving, facilities and her health out of it. Listen more than you talk, and afterward write down what she said, in her words where you can. [1] [2]

**WHY IT GOES HERE** Her days are something she knows better than anyone, and nobody has to agree to anything in order to talk about them.

## 3 Agree how you'll come back to it

Before you finish, ask how she'd like to pick this up again: in the spring, after the holidays, whenever one of you thinks of something. Tell her that nothing she said is fixed and she can change any of it. [1]

**WHY IT GOES HERE** One talk can't hold everything. Knowing there will be another takes the weight off this one.

## What doesn't have to be settled yet

- Whether she will ever need help, or what kind.
- Where she would live.
- Who in the family would do what.
- Anything she'd rather not talk about yet. Write it down as a question for later and leave it there.

**If she'd rather not talk about it**

Then leave it for now. AARP's planning guide for families says that if a first conversation doesn't go well, you can try again, and start small with just one part of what's on your mind. The National Institute on Aging notes that some people feel more comfortable talking with someone else, such as a doctor or someone in their spiritual community.

**What this guide doesn't do**

It doesn't suggest what your wife might need, propose any arrangement, or decide anything. It puts a first conversation in order and leaves everything else for later.

## Ready for the next step?

You know how to ask, where to begin and how you'll come back to it. When you're both ready, the care interview adds the rest: it walks you through your wife's situation area by area, so her wishes sit alongside a full account of how she lives now, in a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

**Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›**

### WHERE THIS COMES FROM

The places to talk, the good-day question and the reminder that nothing said is permanent follow the Conversation Project's starter guide. The advice to listen, to start small and to come back to it another time follows AARP and the National Institute on Aging. The three moves and their order are the Family Care Roadmap's own.


1. The Conversation Project (Institute for Healthcare Improvement), Your Conversation Starter Guide: How to talk about what matters to you and have a say in your health care
2. AARP, Prepare to Care: A Planning Guide for Families
3. National Institute on Aging, Advance Care Planning and Health Care Decisions: Tips for Caregivers and Families


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